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April 28, 1949.

MEETING IN THE PRESIDENT'S OFFICE WITH SENATORS WHERRY AND BRIDGES ON CHINA

At the President's request I attended a meeting in his office today with Senators Bridges and Wherry, which the President had arranged for the purpose of talking with the Senators on the subject of China.

The President made a brief opening review of the situation, the purpose of which was to convince the Senators that a great deal of misinformation was in circulation; that in fact the United States had done everything in its power to help the Chinese Government; and that the present collapse was not through any lack of effort on our part but was due to the inefficiency of the Chinese Administration and the collapse of the country under it.

He then asked the Senators to ask any questions which they had in mind. This led to questions by both Senators, which the President asked me to deal with. I then made a somewhat extended review of the matter along the lines of recent off-the-record talks. Both Senators seemed to be much impressed but not altogether convinced.

Aside from such questions as to whether I felt certain that advice I was getting in the State Department on the subject did not come from Communist sympathisers, the questions were directed to matters of fact, which were explained, and to possibilities of policy which were discussed.

Senator Wherry was particularly impressed by a statement which I made that the talks in 1945-1946 between the Chinese Government and the Communists were not under pressure from General Marshall and were not an idea which were originated either in the State Department or by General Marshall. I explained to him that these talks went back to 1937, when an understanding had been reached between the Nationalist Government and the Communists that, after the Japanese threat had been removed, they would engage in discussions directed toward unifying China. I then went

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Copies sent to:

Mr. Butterworth (FOR ACTION)
Mr. Rusk
Mr. Gross
Mr. Webb

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on to say that this was picked up in 1945 and agreements entered into with the approvel of Chiang Kai-Shek setting up the Consultative Conference and leading to a series of meetings and proposals in China. Senator Wherry had never heard of this and asked whether we could furnish him with some papers so that he might understand this background fully. I told him that we would be glad to do this.

Senator Wherry was also very much interested in Formosa. I explained to him the recent history of Formosa, Chinese misgovernment, and the dangers which would come to Formosa's being used as a haven for refugees, with resulting friction in the island and communist penetration. I said that the best hope would grow from doing everything possible to keep carpetbaggers and refugees out of Formosa and giving the Formosans a chance to express their own desires for their own future.

I think the chief importance of the meeting was as a start for further discussions, with these Senators and perhaps others. Both of them expressed their bafflement with the problem and their inability to learn about it. They were very appreciative of the talk, and I think that this can be used as a foundation for further talks.

I hope that as rapidly as possible I can get to them a memorandum for Senator Wherry on the negotiations, agreements, and discussions between the Communists and Nationalists, with so far as possible, original papers. I should like to have a note written to them at once saying that we will do this and that the actual documents will be along as soon as possible.

~~This note~~ being prepared
by Secretary's office.

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